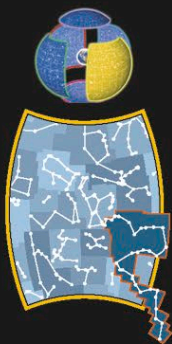


THE RIVER

Eridanus



SIZE RANKING 6

BRIGHTEST STAR

Achernar (α) 0.5

GENITIVE Eridani

ABBREVIATION Eri

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
November–JanuaryFULLY VISIBLE
32°N–89°S

This large constellation represents a river meandering from the foot of Taurus south to Hydrus. Its range in declination of 58 degrees is the greatest of any constellation.

The only star of any note in Eridanus is 1st-magnitude Achernar, or Alpha (α) Eridani, which lies at the southern tip of the constellation. The name Achernar is of Arabic origin and means “river’s end.”

Eridanus features in the story of Phaethon, son of the sun god Helios, who attempted to drive his father’s chariot across the sky. He lost control

and fell into the river below. This river has been identified with two real ones: the Nile in Egypt and the Po in Italy.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

For all its size, Eridanus is short on objects of interest for a small telescope. The best is the multiple star Omicron-2 (σ^2) Eridani (see p.276), also known as 40 Eridani, which includes both a red dwarf and a white one. To the eye, it appears as a 4th-magnitude orange star, but a small telescope reveals a 10th-magnitude companion, the white dwarf. This is the easiest white dwarf to spot with a small telescope. It forms a binary with a fainter red dwarf, although this star may require a telescope with a slightly larger aperture to be detectable.

Two double stars of note are Theta (θ) Eridani, consisting of white stars of 3rd and 4th magnitudes divisible through a small telescope, and 32 Eridani, a contrasting pair of orange and blue stars of 5th and 6th magnitudes, also within range of a small telescope.

The galaxy NGC 1300 is estimated to lie around 75 million light-years away and is too faint for viewing through a small telescope. However, it shows up beautifully on photographs.

MULTIPLE STAR

The primary star of Omicron-2 (σ^2) Eridani is in the center of this photograph, while its white-dwarf and red-dwarf companions overlap each other to the right.



THE RIVER

CELESTIAL RIVER

Eridanus has its source next to Rigel (in Orion) and flows south to Achernar. It is fully visible to almost all of the Southern Hemisphere and half of the Northern.

NGC 1300

This is a classic example of a barred spiral galaxy. The length of its central bar is greater than the diameter of the Milky Way, being 150,000 light-years across.

